

GUITARHUB

FIELD GUIDE
No. 02



MAKE THE HOUR COUNT

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How to practice guitar *effectively.*

The answer is not more hours. It is a smaller target, a slower tempo, and a way to tell whether the last thirty minutes changed anything.

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Practice guitar effectively by isolating the exact spot that fails, slowing it until you play it correctly every attempt, and repeating against a named target instead of a rep count. Keep one hard thing per session, put the repaired passage back in context, and write down where you stopped. Correction produces change. Time at the instrument does not.

This page is about the inside of one session: what to isolate, how slow to take it, and what order the parts go in. How long the session should run is answered on [how long to practice each day](#), and where the sessions sit in a week on [the practice schedule](#).

Practice the failure, not the song

Most of a practice hour goes to material that already works. You start at the top, play until something breaks, and start at the top again. Ten passes through a three-minute song give you ten attempts at the bar that fails and ten run-throughs of everything that never did.

The fix is unglamorous. Find the smallest unit that contains the problem and work on that alone. Usually it is two beats, one chord change, one string crossing, or a single reach your hand cannot make in the time available. If you cannot name the unit, you have not found it yet. *The chorus is sloppy* is a feeling, not a target. One size check: you should be able to play the isolated unit in a few seconds.

Locating it takes a deliberate pass. Play at a tempo where the section mostly holds and stop at the first thing that is not clean. Pushing through to the end is a stage habit, and it hides where the fault is. Mark the bar, then play only the two beats around it.

Some failures have a known repair. A chord change that arrives late usually breaks at one specific finger, not at the whole shape. Strumly's guide to [smoother chord transitions](#) covers how to find which one.

What slow enough actually means

Slow practice is advice everyone gives and almost nobody defines. The usable definition: slow enough that you play the passage correctly on the first attempt, and on every attempt after it, with no mid-phrase recovery.

That last clause is the whole thing. If your hand arrives late and catches up, if a note buzzes and you re-press it, if you flinch and the beat stretches, the tempo is too fast regardless of how it sounded to you. A recovered mistake is still a mistake, and the recovery is part of what you teach your hands.

There is a second marker, more reliable than the first. At the correct tempo you can see the next move before you make it: your fingers are already travelling toward the next shape while the current one is still sounding. If the next chord is a surprise, slow down.

Expect this to feel absurdly slow, and expect to be bored. Boredom is roughly where the tempo starts being useful. The real mistake is picking the speed where it *almost* works: the most tempting tempo available, and the least productive, because it lets you rehearse the error at high fidelity.

From there you climb. Raise the tempo in small increments, hold each step until you get two or three clean passes in a row, and drop back a step the moment a pass is not clean. Dropping back is not a punishment; it is the mechanism. The tempo ladder builder turns one passage into that sequence so you are not choosing numbers mid-session.

Repetition without a target does nothing

Playing something twenty times is not practice. It is twenty samples of your current ability, and it will average toward whatever you already do. A repetition changes something only when it is aimed at a specific correction.

So name the failure before you repeat it. Not *it sounds bad*. Which finger, which beat, which direction. A short list of what it usually turns out to be:

- **Timing.** The notes are right and land in the wrong place. Play against a click and find out whether you rush or drag; those need opposite fixes.
- **Fretting.** A note buzzes or dies. Find the finger and the reason: not enough pressure, the wrong part of the fingertip, or a finger lying flat across a string it should clear.
- **Picking.** The hand crosses strings late, or catches two when it wants one. Watch the picking hand for a few passes instead of the fretting hand. Most players never do.
- **The reach.** The shape is possible but your hand cannot get there in time. That is a preparation problem, and the fix belongs in the bar before the one that fails.
- **Attention.** You can play it while watching your hands and cannot when you are not. The passage is not learned yet, only supervised.

Once it has a name, the repetition gets a criterion. Instead of *play it again*, it becomes *play it with the index finger landing steep enough to clear the next string*. Now every pass has a verdict: it met the criterion or it did not, and three passes tell you something instead of nothing.

A criterion only works if something can tell you whether you met it, and your own ear mid-phrase is the least reliable judge you have available. That problem is large enough to have its own page: [deliberate practice on guitar](#) covers how to get an honest verdict on each attempt when there is no teacher in the room, which is the one part of this the structure below cannot supply.

How to build the session

A session is not a to-do list of everything you want to be better at. It is one repair, protected from the rest of your playing. A structure that survives a real week:

1. **Warm up on something that requires attention.** A few minutes on last session's passage at half its ladder tempo, or a slow chromatic run where you are actually watching your hand. A warm-up you can do while thinking about something else is not warming anything up.
2. **Work one hard thing.** The isolated failure, at ladder tempo, with a named criterion. This is the part that changes your playing, so give it the middle of your attention span rather than the end. Twenty minutes is usually plenty; when the criterion stops improving, stop.
3. **Put it back.** A bar that only works in isolation is not repaired. Play from four bars before the fix to four bars after, at a tempo where the fix survives. That is normally well below the top of your ladder.
4. **Play something.** Finish with music rather than drilling. This is not a reward; it is the only part of the session that tests whether the work transfers to actual playing.

On a short day, do step two and step four and skip the rest. [An intermediate practice routine](#) scales this shape across a week, and Strumly's guide to [designing a practice routine](#) is a reasonable week-level template to adapt.

End the session so the next one starts well

The last five minutes decide the first ten of the next session, and most players spend them badly: push the tempo one more step, fail, push again, stop on the failure. Whatever you played last is what you rehearsed most recently, and it is what your hands offer up tomorrow.

So stop while it is working. When you get a clean pass at a new tempo step, take it and stop. Do not spend the win trying to prove it was not luck; you will find out tomorrow, which is the honest test anyway.

Then write two lines somewhere you will see them: the bar you were working on, the tempo you reached, and the specific thing that was still wrong. The next session starts by reading that instead of by wandering around the fretboard deciding what to do.

Record thirty seconds before you put the guitar down. Your phone is fine and nothing needs to be uploaded anywhere. The recording exists so next week you can hear what this week actually sounded like, which is reliably different from what you remember.

How to tell the practice worked

How it felt is not evidence. Feeling is heavily influenced by how recently you played the passage, which is exactly the variable practice manipulates. Use markers you can check instead.

- **It survives cold.** Play it first, before any warm-up. A passage that only works after ten minutes of preparation is not learned yet.
- **It survives in context.** Play it inside the song, at the song's tempo, with whatever comes immediately before it. Isolation flatters everything.
- **It survives a surprise.** Something goes wrong (a buzz, a missed beat) and you keep going instead of stopping. Stopping means the passage is running on a memorised sequence rather than on control.
- **It survives a day.** Play it tomorrow without practicing it first. Same-day improvement is often short-term familiarity; what is left the next day is what you built.
- **The recording agrees.** Compare today's thirty seconds against the one you made at the start. It is the only marker that does not run through your own ears in real time.

Failing one of these hands you the next target, which is more useful than a vague sense of progress. The song readiness score runs a structured version of this check across a whole song.

Common mistakes

- **Starting from the top every time.** The opening gets practiced far more than the part that needs it.
- **Counting reps instead of naming a target.** Twenty repetitions of an unspecified thing is twenty samples, not twenty corrections.
- **Adding new material before the old material holds.** New songs feel like progress and are the fastest way to accumulate half-finished pieces.
- **Warming up until the session is nearly over.** Twenty comfortable minutes followed by five on the hard thing is a session about avoidance.

- **Practicing with divided attention.** Playing with a screen running in front of you builds the ability to play with a screen running in front of you.

Questions that come up

How long should a guitar practice session be?

Long enough to hold one repair, and no longer. Twenty to thirty focused minutes does more for a specific passage than an hour that starts from the top, because most of that hour lands on material that already works. If you have more time, run a second session later in the day rather than extending the first.

Is it better to practice every day or in longer sessions a few times a week?

More days is usually the better trade for anything technical. A passage is tested by whether it survives overnight, and practicing daily tests it daily. Longer sessions suit learning new material and playing, which is a different job from repairing.

Do I need a metronome for everything?

No. Use it when the problem is timing, when you are climbing a tempo ladder, and when you need an outside opinion on whether you rush. Turn it off when you are working on tone, on a reach, or on anything where subdividing in your head is part of what you are learning.

How do I know if I am practicing too slowly?

There is one real symptom. Below a certain tempo the passage becomes a different physical motion: you place fingers one at a time where you would normally move the whole shape at once. At that point you are rehearsing a motion you will never use. Speed up until the motion matches the passage, then stay there.

GuitarHub Field Guide No. 02. The latest version of this guide, with its tools and links, lives at guitarhub.org/how-to-practice-guitar-effectively.